METRIC

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SUPERSEDING
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COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

PEPPERS, STUFFED WITH BEEF AND RICE, IN SAUCE, FROZEN

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) has authorized the use of this Commercial Item Description (CID).

1. SCOPE. This CID covers frozen peppers, stuffed with beef and rice, in sauce, (stuffed peppers), packed in commercially acceptable containers, suitable for use by Federal, State, local governments, and other interested parties.

2. PURCHASER NOTES. Purchasers *shall specify* the following:

- When analytical requirements are different than specified (Sec. 6.1).
- When analytical requirements need to be verified (Sec. 6.2).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's certification (Sec. 9.1) or USDA certification (Sec. 9.2).

3. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S NOTES. Manufacturer's/distributor's products *shall meet* the requirements of the:

- Processing guidelines (Sec. 4).
- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 6).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's product assurance (Sec. 7).
- Regulatory requirements (Sec. 8).
- Quality assurance provisions: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 9).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 10).

4. PROCESSING GUIDELINES.

4.1 Processing. The stuffed peppers shall be processed in accordance with Current Good Manufacturing Practices (21 Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) Part 110).

4.2 Food security. The stuffed peppers shall be processed and transported in accordance with the Food and Drug Administration's (FDA's) *Guidance for Industry: Food Producers,*

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Processors, and Transporters: Food Security Preventive Measures Guidance.[1] This guidance identifies the kinds of preventive measures food manufacturers, processors, or handlers may take to minimize the risk that food under their control will be subject to tampering or other malicious, criminal, or terrorist actions. The implementation of enhanced food security preventive measures provides for the security of a plant's production processes and includes the storage and transportation of pre-production raw materials, other ingredients, and postproduction finished product.

4.3 Age requirement. Unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the stuffed peppers shall be manufactured not more than 90 days prior to delivery.

5. SALIENT CHARACTERISTICS.

5.1 Ingredients. The stuffed peppers shall contain a beef and rice stuffing mixture, a green bell pepper, sauce and spices, safe and suitable sweeteners and thickeners, and may contain vegetables. All ingredients shall be declared by their common or usual name in descending order of predominance by weight (21 CFR § 101.4(a)) unless exempted by 21 CFR § 101.100.

5.1.1 Beef and Rice Stuffing Mixture. The beef and rice stuffing mixture shall be a homogenous mixture of beef and precooked rice and may contain spices.

5.1.1.1 Meat. The beef shall conform to the applicable provisions of the meat and poultry products inspection and certification requirements (9 CFR Parts 301 to 350). The beef shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Institutional Meat Purchase Specifications (IMPS), including the Acceptable Quality Levels (AQLs) for major and minor defects, and the defect levels specified in Table 100I of the IMPS Quality Assurance Provisions (QAPs). The stuffed peppers shall meet the requirements of the USDA Food Standards and Labeling Policy Book for stuffed peppers with meat in sauce.

5.1.1.2 Rice. The rice shall comply with the FDA Standard of Identity for Enriched Rice (21 CFR § 137.350).

5.1.2 Peppers. The peppers shall be mature, green, sweet bell peppers of similar varietal characteristics.

5.1.3 Sauce and spices. The sauce shall contain tomato puree or tomato paste, and diced tomatoes, and may contain onions, sweeteners, thickeners, salt, and spices, including garlic and other spices common to tomato-based sauce.

5.1.4 Additional ingredients. The stuffed peppers may contain food ingredients permitted by the FDA for thickening, emulsifying, stabilizing, preserving, or enhancing flavor. Food

[1] http://www.fda.gov/Food/GuidanceComplianceRegulatoryInformation/GuidanceDocuments/FoodDefenseandEmergencyResponse/ucm083075.htm

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additives or generally recognized as safe (GRAS) substances used shall be of Food Chemicals Codex Purity or US Pharmacopeia-National Formulary quality and meet the related FDA regulations on food additives or GRAS requirements. Any additional ingredients added directly to the meat components shall comply with the Food Ingredients and Sources of Radiation section of the Regulatory Requirements Under the Federal Meat Inspection Act and the Poultry Products Inspection Act (9 CFR § 424.21), or Safe and Suitable Ingredients Used in the Production of Meat, Poultry, and Egg Products (FSIS Directive 7120.1[2]).

5.1.5 Foreign material. All ingredients shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from foreign material such as plastic pieces, evidence of rodent or insect infestation, and metal contaminants, including, but not limited to, ferrous, non-ferrous, and stainless steel. All tomato products shall comply with the defect action levels specified in the FDA Defect Levels Handbook currently in effect on the date of the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

5.2 Finished product. The finished stuffed peppers shall be a beef and rice mixture in a green bell pepper, cooked in sauce and spices. The finished stuffed peppers shall show no evidence of spoilage, thawing and refreezing, or excessive heating (materially scorched).

5.2.1 Appearance. The stuffed peppers shall not be mushy or pasty. There shall be no foreign color to the product.

5.2.2 Aroma and flavor. The stuffed peppers shall have an aroma and flavor characteristic of prepared stuffed peppers. There shall be no foreign odors or flavors such as, but not limited to, burnt, scorched, stale, rancid, or moldy.

5.2.3 Texture and consistency. The texture of the peppers shall not be rubbery or mushy. The sauce shall not be excessively thin, thick, or pasty. The stuffing shall not be rubbery or tough and the rice shall not be undercooked (hard) or overcooked (mushy).

6. ANALYTICAL REQUIREMENTS.

6.1 Analytical requirements. Unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the stuffed peppers shall comply with the following ranges and tolerances:

Test	Tolerance
Monosodium glutamate (MSG)	Less than 2.27g per 227 g (8 oz) (1 percent) of finished product
Fat	Less than 17.0 g per 227 g (8 oz) of finished product

[2] http://www.fsis.usda.gov/oppde/rdad/fsisdirectives/7120.1.pdf

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Test	Tolerance
Sodium	Less than 1,000 mg per 227 g (8 oz) of finished product
Standard Plate Count	Less than 50,000 CFU per g
Escherichia coli (*E. coli*)	Less than 3 per g using Most Probable Number (MPN) or less than 10 Colony Forming Units (CFU) per g
E. coli O157:H7	Shall be negative
Listeria monocytogenes (*L. monocytogenes*)	Shall be negative
Salmonella	Shall be negative

6.2 Product verification sampling. When USDA verification of analytical requirements is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, analytical testing shall be performed on a composite sample. The composite sample shall be 1.134 kg (2.5 lb) per lot, prepared from a minimum of sixty representative subsamples or retail packages randomly selected from the lot.

6.3 Analytical testing. When specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the analyses shall be made in accordance with the following methods from the AOAC International Official Methods of Analysis (OMA) or the FDA's Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) as specified below:

Test	Method
MSG	970.37
Fat	985.15, 991.36, 2007.04, or 2008.06
Sodium	985.35 or 984.27
Standard Plate Count	990.12 or BAM Ch 3
E. coli	991.14, 998.08, 2011.17, or BAM Ch 4
E. coli O157:H7	2000.14, 2005.03, or BAM Ch 4A
L. monocytogenes	999.06, 2003.12, 2004.02, 2010.02, or BAM Ch 10
Salmonella	967.25, 967.27, 996.08, 2003.09, 2004.03, 2011.03, 2011.17, or BAM Ch 5

6.4 Test results. Test results for MSG shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent. Test results for fat shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 g. Test results for sodium shall be reported to the nearest mg. The test results for standard plate count shall be reported to the nearest 100 CFU per g. The test results for *E. coli* shall be reported to the nearest MPN or CFU. The test results for *E. coli* O157:H7, *L. monocytogenes*, and *Salmonella* shall be reported as positive or negative. Any result not conforming to the analytical requirements shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

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7. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S PRODUCT ASSURANCE. The manufacturer/ distributor shall certify that the stuffed peppers provided shall meet the salient characteristics of this CID, conform to their own specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices, and be the same stuffed peppers offered for sale in the commercial market. The purchaser reserves the right to require proof of conformance.

8. REGULATORY REQUIREMENTS. The meat components and the finished product shall originate and be produced, processed, and stored in compliance with all applicable provisions of the Federal Meat Inspection Act and regulations promulgated thereunder. The delivered stuffed peppers shall comply with all applicable Federal and State mandatory requirements and regulations relating to the preparation, packaging, labeling, storage, distribution, and sale of the stuffed peppers in the commercial marketplace. Delivered stuffed peppers shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act, the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act, and regulations promulgated thereunder. When a known allergen is included in the stuffed peppers, the stuffed peppers shall comply with the allergen labeling requirements of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act. When the stuffed peppers are used for the National School Lunch Program, the stuffed peppers shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Child Nutrition (CN) Programs.

9. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS. *Purchaser shall specify 9.1 or 9.2.*

9.1 Manufacturer's/distributor's certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the manufacturer/distributor shall certify that the finished stuffed peppers distributed meet or exceed the requirements of this CID.

9.2 USDA certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order that product quality, acceptability or both be determined, the Specialty Crops Inspection Division (SCI), Fruit and Vegetable Program (FV), Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), USDA, shall be the certifying agency. SCI inspectors shall certify the quality and acceptability of the stuffed peppers in accordance with SCI procedures which include: selecting random samples of the stuffed peppers, evaluating the samples for conformance with the salient characteristics of this CID and other contractual requirements, and documenting the findings on official SCI score sheets or certificates. In addition, when required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, SCI will examine the stuffed peppers for conformance to the U.S. Standards for Condition of Food Containers (7 CFR Part 42) in effect on the date of the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

10. PACKAGING. Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and case marking shall be commercial unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

11. USDA INSPECTION NOTES. When Section 9.2 is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, USDA certification shall include evaluation of the quality and

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condition of samples of stuffed peppers and compliance with requirements in the following areas:

- Processing guidelines (Sec. 4).
- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements *when specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order* (Sec. 6). When USDA analytical testing is specified, SCI inspection personnel shall select samples and submit them to the USDA, Science and Technology Programs (S&TP) laboratory for analysis.
- Packaging requirements (Sec. 10 or *as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order*).

12. REFERENCE NOTES.

12.1 USDA certification contact. For a USDA certification contact the **Chief, Inspection Branch, SCI, FV, AMS, USDA, STOP 0240, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0240, telephone (202) 720-2482, fax (202) 720-0393, or via E-mail: Nathaniel.Taylor@ams.usda.gov.**

12.2 Analytical testing and technical information contact. For USDA technical information on analytical testing, contact **the Science & Technology Program (S&TP), AMS, USDA, STOP 0272, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0272, telephone (202) 720-5231 or via E-mail: Alan.Post@ams.usda.gov or Ruihong.Guo@ams.usda.gov.**

12.3 Sources of documents.

12.3.1 Sources of information for nongovernmental documents are as follows:

Copies of the AOAC International OMA may be obtained from: **AOAC International, 481 North Frederick Avenue, Suite 500, Gaithersburg, MD 20877-2417, telephone (301) 924-7077. Internet address: http://www.aoac.org for nonmembers and http://www.eoma.aoac.org for members and AOAC OMA subscribers.**

Copies of the Food Chemicals Codex and U.S. Pharmacopeia may be purchased from: **United States Pharmacopeia Convention, 12601 Twinbrook Parkway, Rockville, MD 20877, telephone (800) 227-8772 or (301) 881-0666, Fax (301) 816-8148 or on the Internet at: http://www.usp.org.**

12.3.2 Sources of information for governmental documents are as follows:

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Applicable provisions of the U.S. Standards for Condition of Food Containers are contained in 7 CFR Part 42, information on the Meat and Poultry Products Inspection and Voluntary Inspection and Certification are contained in 9 CFR Parts 301 to 350, the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act are contained in 16 CFR Parts 500 to 503, and the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act are contained in 21 CFR Parts 1 to 199. These documents may be purchased from: **Superintendent of Documents, New Orders, P.O. Box 979050, St. Louis, MO 63197-9000. Credit card (Visa, MasterCard, Discover/ NOVUS, and American Express) purchases may be made by calling the Superintendent of Documents on (866) 512-1800, (202) 512-1800. These documents may also be obtained free of charge on the Internet at: http://www.gpo.gov/fdsys/browse/collectionCfr.action?collectionCode=CFR.**

Copies of Guidance for Industry - Food Producers, Processors, and Transporters: Food Security Preventive Measures Guidance is available online from: **FDA, Center for Food Safety and Applied Nutrition (CFSAN) on the Internet at: http://www.fda.gov/Food/GuidanceComplianceRegulatoryInformation/GuidanceDocuments/FoodDefenseandEmergencyResponse/ucm083075.htm.**

Copies of the USDA's Food Standards and Labeling Policy Book are available online from **USDA, FSIS, at: http://www.fsis.usda.gov/oppde/larc/policies/labeling_policy_book_082005.pdf.**

Copies of the Institutional Meat Purchase Specifications (IMPS) are available online from **USDA, AMS on the Internet at: http://www.ams.usda.gov/AMSv1.0/ams.fetchTemplateData.do?template=TemplateP&navID=IMPS&rightNav1=IMPS&topNav=&leftNav=&page=LivestockStandardizationIMPS&resultType=&acct=lsstd**.

Copies of FSIS Directive 7120.1, Safe and Suitable Ingredients Used in the Production of Meat, Poultry, and Egg Products, are available online from **USDA, FSIS, at: http://www.fsis.usda.gov/oppde/rdad/fsisdirectives/7120.1.pdf.**

Copies of the FDA Defect Level Handbook are available online from **FDA at: http://www.fda.gov/Food/GuidanceComplianceRegulatoryInformation/GuidanceDocuments/Sanitation/ucm056174.htm**.

Copies of the FDA Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) are available online from **FDA at: http://www.fda.gov/Food/ScienceResearch/LaboratoryMethods/BacteriologicalAnalyticalManualBAM/default.htm.**

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Copies of this CID, the U.S. Standards for Condition of Food Containers (7 CFR Part 42), and beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc. and any data which may improve this CID are available from or provided to: **Chief, Standardization Branch, SCI, FV, AMS, USDA, STOP 240, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0240, telephone (202) 720-5021, Fax (202) 690-1527, via E-mail: CIDS@ams.usda.gov, or on the Internet at: www.ams.usda.gov/CommercialItemDescription.**

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